# QUESTION 4: ESCALATION POLICY

DG Interns Hub Cybersecurity Internship – Week 5 Submission

**Student Name:** Gunjan **Track:** SOC Analyst Tier 1 **Topic:** Escalation Criteria & Handoff Standards

## 1. WHAT IS AN ESCALATION POLICY?

An **Escalation Policy** is a predefined set of SOC guidelines that dictates when, how, and to whom a Tier 1 analyst should transfer a security ticket. It defines the formal handoff rules between different analyst tiers (L1 to L2, L2 to L3/Incident Response) and ensures that critical threats receive timely, specialized intervention without operational bottlenecks.

## 2. WHEN SHOULD AN L1 ANALYST ESCALATE TO L2?

An L1 analyst should not attempt to remediate every incident independently. Escalation to Tier 2 (L2) is required under the following specific conditions:

**Confirmed True Positive on Critical Assets:** Real attacks targeting domain controllers, database servers, or executive endpoints. **Active Adversary Behavior / Exploitation:** Signs of post-exploitation activity such as credential dumping, command-and-control (C2) communication, or lateral movement. **Complex Forensics Needed:** Incidents requiring deep packet analysis, memory dump analysis, or custom malware reverse engineering beyond L1 scope. **Remediation Authority Exceeded:** Actions requiring broad containment, such as isolating production servers, revoking executive Active Directory accounts, or editing core firewall rules. **SLA Exceeded / High Uncertainty:** When initial investigation hits a roadblock or triage time limits (e.g., 30 minutes) are reached without a clear determination.

## 3. ESSENTIAL INFORMATION IN AN ESCALATION TICKET

To ensure smooth handoffs and prevent L2 analysts from duplicating work, an escalation ticket must be detailed and self-contained:

| Component | Required Details |
|---|---|
| **Ticket Metadata** | Alert ID, Triggered SIEM Rule Name, Severity Level, Timestamp of Detection (UTC). |
| **Target & Origin Context** | Affected Hostname, IP Address, MAC Address, Targeted User Account, Source IP/Geoloc. |
| **Technical Evidence** | Process trees, file hashes (SHA256/MD5), raw command-line arguments, SIEM log snippets. |
| **Enrichment & Intel** | VirusTotal, AbuseIPDB, or AlienVault OTX lookups and reputation scores. |
| **Analyst Summary & Reason** | Clear narrative of steps performed, why it is a True Positive, and why L2 action is requested. |

## 4. PRACTICAL ESCALATION SCENARIO EXAMPLE

**Scenario: Credential Dumping via LSASS**

**Alert Triggered:** "Mimikatz / Memory Dumping Tool Detected" on `FIN-WORKSTATION-09`.

**L1 Investigation Steps:**

Checked EDR process tree: `lsass.exe` was targeted by an unauthorized process `procdump.exe` initiated from PowerShell. Verified process hash on VirusTotal: 58/72 vendors flagged the executable as malicious. Confirmed user account `corp\j_doe` belongs to a non-admin Finance employee.

**Escalation Decision:** L1 cannot perform host isolation or memory forensics. L1 compiles the process log, attaches VirusTotal evidence, assigns ticket to L2 Incident Response, and sends an urgent notification in the SOC escalation channel.

## 5. TERMINOLOGY & REFERENCES

**Tier 2 (L2) Analyst:** Incident Responder responsible for deep investigation, host containment, and advanced remediation. **Handoff:** Formal transfer of ticket responsibility from one operational tier to another.

**References:**


• NIST SP 800-61 Rev. 2 - Incident Handling Escalation Workflows: **https://csrc.nist.gov/**
• SANS SOC Resources & Escalation Frameworks: **https://www.sans.org/**